



POLL PLANS: CPI(M) bosses have set the ball rolling

Not If But When

Even as CPI(M) prepares its cadres for early elections, it has strategically placed the onus of the Government's survival on the Congress. A pull out of support is certain, only its timing is not.

■ **By Satarupa Bhattachariya in Kolkata**

For three days last week, all eyes were on the narrow Alimuddin Street in Kolkata. Close to 60 members of the CPI(M) Central Committee and a dozen Politburo members had assembled at the Muzaffar Ahmad Bhawan, CPI(M) headquarters, where the party was holding one of its most crucial meetings in recent times. Upon the deliberations and the final decision depended the fate of the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre.

The party and its other allies in the Left Front had, in spirit, withdrawn their crucial support to the Government in early August itself after Prime Minister Manmohan Singh dared them through a newspaper interview. That was the beginning of the end of the Left's working

THE RED CARD

CPI(M) chargesheet against UPA

- The Centre has been "uncaring, insensitive and callous". It has violated the common minimum programme.
- Has failed to tackle the agrarian crisis which has led to suicides by many farmers.
- The Government bought wheat at Rs 850 per quintal from Indian farmers and paid double to the foreign traders.
- Prices of essential commodities have spiralled. The public distribution system has collapsed.
- It is giving concessions to big business houses including control over gas pricing.
- There are no specific allocations for minorities; only tokenism.

relationship with the Congress. Since then, both sides have been carrying around the dead weight of their three-year-old association. "We have found UPA Government to be uncaring, insensitive and callous about fulfilling people's needs," CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat said at the end of three hectic days of deliberations.

With the Congress unwilling to let go the Indo-US nuclear cooperation agreement and CPI(M) in favour of the lame duck Government carrying on until the end of its tenure in 2009, the bilateral treaty would automatically end in a slow death. But if the UPA Government were to firm up its official position at the International Atomic Energy Agency or the Nuclear Suppliers Group, a public announcement of the withdrawal of the Left support to UPA would soon follow. "The Congress is dependent on Left support. It must concede if it wants to stay in power,"